

Misused linguistic evidence in a study of media bias

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Abstract

Holly Jackson (2024b) claims to present a “large-scale proof of historical bias against Palestine” in coverage by *The New York Times*, using computational linguistic methods. Fundamental errors in both linguistic analysis and computational methodology vitiate the study. The analysis rests on a profound misunderstanding of the grammatical notion of passive voice, and the quantitative results rest entirely on the failed grammatical analysis. Moreover, the computational methodology employs overly narrow keyword filters which are not specified in the published paper. It excludes relevant data, and lacks a necessary baseline for comparison. The systematic bias for which the paper claims to have provided a “proof” remains conjectural. The use of computational linguistic tools in media analysis demands linguistic analyses that are sound and coherent, and computational analysis that is rigorous and consistent. The broader relevance of this case of grammatical misconception leveraging a sweeping political indictment is that it shows fine details of linguistic analysis can have large consequences for political analysis: computational linguistic results purporting to measure bias may in fact manufacture it. Our paper therefore speaks directly to the core concern of political–linguistic scholarship: how language choices mediate ideology, power, and public deliberation.

Introduction

The study of media bias is not merely a technical exercise in corpus counting; it is a lens on how linguistic form participates in the construction of political reality. Within the critical discourse analysis tradition, the distribution of grammatical resources such as agency, transitivity and voice has long been tied to the (re)production of power relations (Fairclough 1995, van Dijk 1998). When those resources are wrongly analysed, the resulting quantitative claims can misinform scholarship, policy debate, and public trust in journalism. In what follows we examine one recent such case, Jackson (2024b), to show how unsound linguistic premises cascade into a false ‘proof’ of anti-Palestinian bias in *The New York Times* (which Jackson often abbreviates as “NYT”).

The issue of whether there has been media bias in coverage of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict is certainly a matter that deserves attention; and it has received it. Earlier academic studies and media commentary have examined the ways in which narrative framing, source selection, and terminology might favor particular perspectives in this contentious domain (Zelizer et al. 2002, Viser 2003, Bazian 2015, Tenenboim-Weinblatt et al. 2016, Neureiter 2017, DeGraff 2024a, DeGraff 2024b, Dudum 2024, Pinker 2025). A rigorous computational analysis could in principle offer valuable insights into patterns that qualitative studies cannot easily capture. Unfortunately, Jackson's paper fails at every level to provide such an analysis.

The paper's methodology hinges on the correct identification of active versus passive constructions, and making a connection between these identifications and statements about Israeli or Palestinian agency. It makes the mistake of failing to distinguish the syntactic property of being a passive clause from the vague and subjective semantic notion of being inexplicit in some way about agency or responsibility. This is a familiar error, as Pullum 2014 documents extensively. In one case Schwammenthal (2012) quotes *The Economist* saying that "Violent clashes and provocations erupted whenever the peace process seemed on the verge of concrete steps forward", and comments that "as Journalism 101 courses explain, the passive voice erupts whenever the journalist is trying to obscure the truth." Journalism courses may indeed teach that, but there is no passive clause here: *erupted* is an active intransitive verb.

Incidentally, the bias Schwammenthal alleges in *The Economist* is anti-Israeli and pro-Palestinian, the opposite of what Jackson claims to find in *The New York Times*. His claim is that the violence mentioned was attributable to Palestinian terrorist attacks following Israeli peace moves. Reuters has also been accused of pro-Israeli bias expressed through judicious use of the passive voice (see Managing Team 2003), but in that case too, passives and actives were not correctly distinguished.

Mostly when critics fail to identify grammatical passives, nothing much is at stake: some anecdotal critique of writing style is rendered meaningless, or a writer is falsely accused of using passives (the tacit assumption being that passives are always bad). But in this case we are not talking about a throw-away style criticisms, but a supposedly empirical research contribution in a peer-reviewed journal, to support an implied moral judgment on the ethics of the entire journalistic staff of one of America's premier newspapers. That is much more serious than mere stylistic nitpicking.

The way Jackson counted relevant instances introduces a different flaw that would be vitiating even if passives were always correctly identified. The study relies on an overly narrow and arguably biased filter, counting sentences as relevant only when the grammatical subject matches a small predefined list of terms for "Israeli" or "Palestinian". This ignores crucial context, such as the agent role in passive clauses (often the focus of bias analysis) and the use of related but unlisted terms to refer to the parties involved. It also explicitly excludes sentences deemed relevant to both sides. Furthermore, the paper provides no established baseline or counterfactual model for what unbiased reporting patterns would look like, making it impossible to meaningfully interpret the statistical patterns presented as evidence of bias.

The editors of the journal that published the paper refused to take these flaws seriously when they were pointed out (see the account on *Quillette* by Kamm 2025), which raises concerns about

quality, peer review, and editorial standards. Our aim in this response is to put on record the paper's failures to provide evidence about media bias in *The New York Times*.

Our critique aligns with a growing body of work in the *Journal of Language and Politics* that analyzes the grammatical construction of conflict actors and events (e.g., Matu & Lubbe 2007, KhosraviNik 2010, Hart 2013). In what follows we stress that the validity of such analyses hinges on accurate linguistic annotation and transparent computational processing.

Errors in linguistic analysis: The passive voice

A core component of the analysis in Jackson's paper rests on the classification of sentences (more precisely, individual clauses) as active or passive. However, the paper as first published betrayed a misunderstanding of this basic grammatical distinction.

'Voice' is the term traditionally used to name the grammatical dimension on which *Russia invaded Ukraine* differs from *Ukraine was invaded by Russia*. It is a singularly unhelpful term, because the active/passive distinction has nothing to do with voice in the phonetic sense (*his loud, clear singing voice*) or the literary sense (*her distinctive authorial voice*). However, the term as applied to grammar has a clear definition, as we explain below.

Jackson sets out her approach to grammatical analysis as follows:

I identify whether actions by Palestinian and Israeli groups are being described in the active or passive voice. For every verb, I identified the perpetrator and recipient of the action (i.e. whether they were a Palestinian or Israeli group or individual). [Jackson 2024b:120]

Voice is clearly being taken here to be a semantic property of group descriptions, dependent on whether agents ("perpetrators") are specified. This is not the syntactic category familiar to grammarians. The extent misunderstanding it leads to was starkly illustrated by an example Jackson herself selected (from Kingsley 2021), in the first version of her paper, to demonstrate the bias she is concerned with:

More than 67 Palestinians, including 16 children, have died since the start of the conflict on Monday

Jackson cited this sentence as an instance of passive voice, on the grounds that it obscures the identity of the "perpetrators" responsible for the deaths. But it is not a passive at all: *have died* is the present perfect active form of the intransitive verb *die*. A sentence like *Our orchids have died* is not a devious rhetorical trick to conceal someone's responsibility for orchid murder. Such sentences exhibit none of the structural characteristics of a passive construction.¹

¹ After Oliver Kamm brought this grammatical slip to the attention of the editors, Jackson acknowledged her error, and published a correction to her paper (see our bibliography entry for Jackson 2024b). The correction uses the example *More than 230 Palestinians were killed in Gaza*, which is indeed a passive. However, we will show that the error this corrects is far from being the only failing of her paper.

Passive clauses in English are defined by their distinctive syntactic structure. The main verb is transitive (i.e., capable of taking a direct object) and is in its past participle form. Typically there is an additional verb, often the copula (the auxiliary verb known as *be*), but sometimes the verb *get*, as in *He got killed*, or a verb like *have*, as in *The government had him killed* (for further details see Huddleston, Pullum and Reynolds 2002:362–371). To illustrate, these examples are both passive:

- (1) a. *Six civilians were killed in the shooting.* [Passive, no agent]
- b. *Six civilians were killed by the soldiers.* [Passive, with agent]

But notice that passive clauses may omit agents, as in (1a), or include them in *by*-phrases, as in (1b). Inclusion or omission of a noun phrase denoting the agent is an entirely orthogonal matter: some passives lack any reference to an agent, but so do many actives. No agent or causer of the action is specified in any of these active clauses:

- (2) a. *The stock market crashed.*
- b. *Many civilians died in the conflict.*
- c. *Fighting erupted near the border.*
- d. *There is trouble brewing.*

As Pullum (2014) shows at length, it is common in popular discourse for passive voice to be confused with the semantic property of not specifying the doer of an action, and Jackson made this familiar mistake. The passive clauses known to syntacticians as “long passives”, like (1b), are ideal for making agents of actions explicit. Being a passive clause is neither a necessary nor a sufficient condition for being inexplicit about agency, and exactly the same is true for active clauses.

Jackson’s paper contains multiple instances of phrases like “referred to Palestinians in the passive voice.” This is a conceptual error. The passive is a kind of clause, not a mode of reference. Consider a sentence like *Violent clashes were observed between Palestinian and Israeli demonstrators*. This is a passive clause that mentions both Palestinians and Israelis. Are the Palestinians being “referred to ... in the passive voice”? Are the Israelis?

These questions have no answers, because they are confused: there is no such thing as being “referred to in the passive voice”. The notion Jackson seeks to capture is certainly not to be equated with being the referent of the subject noun phrase in a passive clause, because this does not align with what Jackson is looking for. It should be obvious that a sentence with *Palestinians* as the subject in a passive clause might express a bias in the direction of sympathy for the Palestinians (as in *Palestinians are homeless and driven from the homeland*, from *The Wall Street Journal*, 1987), or might suggest the opposite (as in *Palestinians have been stirred by Islamic fundamentalism*, from *The Wall Street Journal*, 1988). And a passive clause may either conceal agency (*Several Palestinians were shot*) or identify the agent very explicitly (*Several Palestinians were shot by Israeli soldiers*).

Implications for methodological validity

Jackson's approach magnifies her conceptual error. The problems extend far beyond misclassifying any specific example. The paper overlooks the crucial role of context in interpretation. Even when a passive construction lacks an explicit agent phrase (a preposition phrase with *by*), the surrounding text or shared knowledge often makes the agent or cause perfectly clear. Consider the following examples drawn from the corpus data used by Jackson (Ferraro et al. 2018):

- (3) a. *The Israelis accuse Saadat of ordering the murder of the Israel's tourism minister, Rehavam Zeevi, who was gunned down in a Jerusalem hotel on Oct. 17.*
- b. *The group said it was in retaliation for the assassination of Saadat's predecessor, Abu Ali Mustapha, who was killed in a rocket attack on his office.*

In (3a), the main clause attributes the order for the assassination of Zeevi to Saadat, making the ultimate responsibility clear, even though the passive verb phrase *was gunned down* has no syntactically overt agent (the agent is potentially unknown). Adding a generic phrase like *by assassins* would offer little clarification beyond what *gunned down* already conveys in this context; the significant information regarding unlawful killing is already provided.

Similarly, in (3b), while the agent of *was killed* is omitted, the cause or means (in a rocket attack) is specified immediately following the verb. For readers familiar with the conflict context surrounding the targeted assassination of a figure like Mustapha, the likely agent responsible for such an attack is strongly suggested. Explicitly adding the agent (e.g., *in an Israeli rocket attack*) would strengthen this inference into an assertion, but doesn't dramatically change the core understanding already available from the description and context.

It does not constitute bias on the part of a newspaper if it reports an event in a way that clearly implies, for any literate and attentive reader, who is responsible for the action. Normal prose never states explicitly every single thing that could possibly be made explicit. When a journalist writes *Houses below the breached dam were swept away* (a passive with no *by*-phrase) it is not reasonable to charge bias on the grounds that the phrase *by the water that flowed through the breach* was not added. We know how dams and flood waters work.

The supposed connection between voice and bias

Jackson nowhere establishes the plausibility of treating passive voice as a valid proxy for media bias. Her entire justification consists of a single sentence: "An analysis of voice is common in other studies of bias because the passive voice, which is often discouraged in formal writing, allows the writer to de-emphasize or entirely omit the perpetrator of an action in a sentence" (Jackson 2024b:120). This perfunctory claim is the sole theoretical support offered for connecting grammatical voice to bias. She provides no substantive discussion of what distribution of active/passive constructions would characterize unbiased reporting, or why differences in voice usage across subjects would necessarily indicate bias rather than reflecting other factors such as prose style, reporting conventions, information presentation, or the nature of the events being covered.

Use of passive clauses has certainly been discouraged by writing advice sources since the beginning of the 20th century, going back to Strunk (1918), but those sources often give very

poor advice, many of them being written by authors who cannot tell an active from a passive anyway (see Pullum 2014). Moreover, they nearly always ignore the fact that sometimes (depending on whether new information is being introduced) a passive is exactly right for expressing the intended meaning. It should not be forgotten that in normal prose by excellent professional writers, it is virtually always the case that between 10 and 20 percent of the transitive verbs are in passive clauses.

Establishing the validity of a quantitative measure for an abstract concept like media bias demands more than face-value interpretation. As Carmines and Zeller (1979) note, criterion-related validity is often inapplicable to such concepts due to the lack of suitable external criteria, and content validity assessment remains subjective. Instead, validation primarily relies on establishing construct validity – demonstrating empirically that the measure behaves as expected within a network of theoretically related concepts. This requires testing specific hypotheses about how voice patterns should correlate with other indicators or dimensions of bias. Jackson’s paper offers no such theoretical framework or empirical tests, failing to establish the construct validity necessary to justify voice distribution as a measure of bias.

In the absence of an established foundational connection between the proxy measure (grammatical voice) and the object of study (media bias), the subsequent statistical analysis becomes an exercise in counting grammatical constructions that bear no demonstrated relationship to the intended research question.

Computational methodology

Beyond the fundamental linguistic errors concerning passive voice, Jackson’s computational methodology, as she describes and used it, suffers from critical flaws in transparency, implementation, and conceptualization that render its quantitative results unreliable as a measure of media bias. While the paper claims to have used “state-of-the-art natural language processing toolkits” – specifically Keras (Chollet et al. 2015); NLTK (Bird, Klein, & Loper 2021), Scikit-learn (Pedregosa et al. 2011) spaCy (Honnibal & Montani 2021) – and claims high accuracy for its models, such tools require linguistically informed application and validation. The author’s misunderstanding of the core grammatical concept being investigated compromises her ability to correctly design the computational analysis, critically evaluate the tool’s output, or perform the claimed “qualitative validation step” (Jackson 2024b:116).

The subject filters

A key methodological flaw lies in the extremely narrow filter apparently used to determine subject relevance. The specific words used to identify “Israeli” or “Palestinian” subjects are not disclosed within the published paper, but can be found only by scrutinizing the Python scripts, hindering reproducibility and critical assessment. Examination of the author’s publicly available code (Jackson 2024a) reveals that it classifies voice only for sentences where the grammatical subject (or its directly associated modifiers) explicitly matches one of the terms within the following short, predefined lists:

- Israeli relevance: *Israel, Israeli, Israelis, IDF, I.D.F.*
- Palestinian relevance: *Palestine, Palestinian, Palestinians, PLO, P.L.O., Fatah*

The paper provides no justification for the specific composition or limited size of these lists. This selection represents a critically consequential exercise of “researcher degrees of freedom” (Gelman 2018). Given the list’s asymmetry and failure to cover key actors, particularly on the Palestinian side (discussed below), this undocumented choice severely undermines the foundation of the comparative analysis. It also fails to address the inherent trade-off between precision (ensuring captured subjects definitely belong to the target group) and recall (capturing a representative range of references). The lack of justification is particularly problematic given the complexity of referring expressions – a significant area of study in linguistics – and their especially nuanced nature in reporting on the two Intifadas, where terminology carries distinct political implications and where the groups involved change over time.

Furthermore, the lack of justification for the keyword lists is compounded by the paper’s apparent treatment of the First Intifada (approximately 1987–1993) and the Second (approximately 2000–2005) as uniform periods for filtering via a single keyword set. These conflicts differed significantly in their characteristics, primary actors, and international context. For instance, the prominence of groups like Hamas grew substantially by the time of the Second Intifada, yet key terms referring to it seem absent from the filter lists used, while terms perhaps more central to the First Intifada (like “PLO”) are included. Applying a single, static, and narrow filter across these distinct historical periods without justification further undermines the methodology’s ability to capture relevant data accurately and highlights its insensitivity to crucial contextual shifts.

The filtering also ignores the significant asymmetry between the conflict parties’ representation in the lists. While one side is primarily represented by a state actor and its military (terms mostly included), the lists fail to reflect the evolving Palestinian representation. The PLO (included) was key during the First Intifada, but the Palestinian Authority (PA), Hamas, and other major factions central to the Second Intifada (like Islamic Jihad, PFLP, and Al-Aqsa Martyrs Brigades) are all absent. Crucial terms related to status or geography (e.g., *refugee*, *militant*, *West Bank*, *Gaza*) are also missing.

This narrowness means sentences are excluded based merely on the lexical choice of the subject term, disproportionately impacting Palestinian representation. For instance, an active sentence like *Hamas fighters launched several rockets* would be entirely excluded despite its relevance to voice usage concerning Palestinian actors. Similarly, a passive construction like *the checkpoint was attacked by militants from Gaza* would likely be ignored because *checkpoint* is not on a keyword list, discarding information about action and agency relevant to the conflict.

Furthermore, the filter discards sentences where the head noun of the subject itself is neutral (i.e., not on the keyword lists) even when the sentence clearly relates to the conflict parties through context, agents, or modifiers, as illustrated by examples drawn from the corpus used by Jackson (Ferraro et al. 2018):

- (4) a. *a leader of Al Aksa Martyrs Brigade killed ... by an Israeli shell.*
- b. *That proposal was not only adopted by the Arab summit...*
- c. *The Saudi initiative has now been turned into an Arab initiative.*
- d. *the Arab leaders are being driven...*

In these examples, the passive clauses are discarded because the grammatical subjects (*leader*, *proposal*, *initiative*, *leaders*) are absent from the keyword lists, ignoring readily available contextual information linking them to the conflict parties.

Additionally, the logic of the script used explicitly requires exclusive relevance to one side based on the subject keyword, meaning subjects relating to both (e.g., *Israeli-Palestinian violence*) are systematically ignored. This arbitrary exclusion further distorts the dataset intended to represent reporting on the conflict.

The compounding effect of these filtering decisions is a dataset that is fundamentally unsuitable for valid comparative analysis. What Jackson presents as differences in voice distribution or sentiment scores between Israeli and Palestinian subjects likely reflects little more than artifacts of the filtering methodology interacting with natural linguistic patterns of reference and the inherent asymmetries of the chosen keywords. This arbitrary and asymmetric filtering renders any subsequent quantitative comparison between the groups meaningless as a measure of reporting patterns, let alone as evidence for media bias.

Technical implementation concerns

Further doubts arise from the technical implementation suggested by the associated code (Jackson 2024a). The logic used to automatically detect voice appears overly simplistic, likely examining only the primary verb structure within the main clause of each sentence. Such an approach inherently ignores subordinate clauses, whether active or passive. For instance, in a structure like *The document, which was released yesterday, contained errors*, the passive construction within the relative clause would likely be missed. Corpus studies suggest that the proportion of the passive may not differ significantly between main and subordinate clauses (e.g. Alvin2014a), so this may not systematically bias analyses in a predictable way, but it discards a good deal of relevant data. Thus, Jackson’s claim to have identified the perpetrator and recipient “for every verb,” is far from accurate.

Missing counterfactual analysis

The study lacks any established baseline or counterfactual model for what patterns of voice distribution would characterize unbiased reporting on asymmetric conflicts. Without such a baseline, it is impossible to meaningfully interpret the statistical differences that Jackson presents as evidence of bias. The paper simply assumes that equal distribution of voice constructions across subjects would indicate neutrality – an assumption that ignores how different types of events, actors, and journalistic conventions might naturally produce different syntactic patterns regardless of bias.

Computational authority and conceptual opacity

It is a striking irony that computational sophistication can serve not to enhance analytical rigour but rather to mask fundamental conceptual inadequacies. This phenomenon – taking technical complexity to confer an unwarranted epistemological authority – has broader implications for interdisciplinary research employing computational methods.

Jackson’s paper illustrates what (Broussard 2018:7) terms “technochauvinism” – an uncritical preference for computational solutions regardless of their appropriateness to the problem at hand. By deploying technical terminology (“regression model with over 90 percent accuracy based on a

carefully validated word bank” (Jackson 2024b, abstract) and referencing “state-of-the-art natural language processing toolkits” (Jackson 2024b, abstract), Jackson creates what boyd [sic] and Crawford (2012:663) describe as an “aura of truth, objectivity, and accuracy.” This computational authority effectively diverts attention from the paper’s basic conceptual errors in linguistic analysis.

The deployment of sophisticated computational methods creates a form of opacity that operates at two levels. First, there is what Burrell (2016:4) identifies as opacity “stemming from the current state of affairs where writing (and reading) code is a specialist skill,” where specialized knowledge is required to evaluate methodological choices. Few readers of *Media, War & Conflict* likely possess the combined expertise in linguistics, stylistics, natural language processing, journalistic practice, and Middle East politics needed to fully scrutinize Jackson’s methods. Second, there is what we might term “conceptual opacity,” where fundamentally flawed premises are hidden beneath layers of technical implementation.

This opacity is particularly problematic when computational methods are applied to politically charged questions. As Crawford (2021) argues, technical systems can serve to launder subjectivity: they can represent value-laden judgments as seemingly objective, quantitative findings. In Jackson’s case, the computational apparatus transforms a basic misunderstanding of English grammar, and a vitiatingly narrow filter on what words will count as examples, into an ostensibly data-driven “proof” of media bias. What appears as objective computation is, in fact, subjective interpretation; what masquerades as linguistic science remains, at core, political preference.

Concluding remarks

The purported “large-scale proof” of systematic, disproportionate anti-Palestinian bias in *The New York Times* does not exist: the claim of bias is entirely unsupported by the evidence provided in Jackson (2024b). The paper makes an unwarranted leap from flawed linguistic analysis to unsubstantiated conclusions – essentially, charges about a lack of journalistic or editorial integrity.

Jackson offers no reason for thinking that a difference in raw counts of subjects in passive clauses, even if accurately measured, would indicate any kind of bias. After all, a sentence like *Palestinians have been shamefully treated* has the noun *Palestinians* in the subject role of a passive clause, yet clearly expresses sympathy with the Palestinians. Her paper disregards plausible alternative explanations for observed differences in voice usage; it neglects the issue of how events themselves shape reporting choices; it neglects how journalistic conventions influence voice selection; and it neglects how actual agency distribution affects syntactic patterns. Her analysis jumps directly from differential counts produced by a flawed methodology to a very strong claim about bias, ignoring the subtle linguistic and contextual factors associated with passive clauses (Ward et al. 2002, Pullum 2014). Although the paper includes a discussion of limitations, that section fails to critically interrogate the study’s foundational assumptions or the potential impact of its core methodology on the results. Instead of demonstrating a rigorous search for potential weaknesses in the study’s main thrust, the discussion focuses on secondary or speculative points.

For instance, Jackson speculates whether the NLP tools themselves might carry an “anti-Arab, anti-Muslim bias” due to training on corpora with “Orientalist sentiments” (Jackson2024b:123). While algorithmic bias is a valid general concern, its prominence here – absent specific substantiation and serving primarily to deflect from unaddressed core flaws in linguistic understanding and methodological design – is revealing. Ultimately, the limitations section does not reflect a genuine attempt to identify or grapple with the most significant factors that could undermine the study’s central claims about bias.

The study also fails to account for how source accessibility disparities and asymmetries in the conflict might naturally affect reporting patterns irrespective of bias. For example, Israeli government sources, benefiting from robust state communication infrastructure, generally have a greater capacity for regular engagement with international media through briefings and official statements, while Palestinian sources operate under significant infrastructural constraints and restrictions imposed by Israel (Wahab 2025). This asymmetry is reflected in sourcing patterns, where outlets like the *NYT* have historically used Israeli officials as sources far more frequently than Palestinian officials (Viser 2003). If such practical realities of conflict reporting are not addressed, differences in patterns of using active or passive clauses cannot validly be interpreted as evidence of bias.

We stress again that we are not dismissing the possibility of journalistic bias or the potential value of investigating how media language might obscure agency or downplay certain actors’ roles – which was Jackson’s goal. Studying such phenomena through linguistic analysis could be a valid and important endeavor in media research. But the project would require a sophisticated interdisciplinary approach. It would necessitate a careful combination of deep linguistic expertise (to correctly identify relevant structures beyond mishandled traditional grammatical labels), sound computational methodology (appropriately designed and validated for the specific linguistic task), and substantive domain knowledge (taking account of reporting conventions, source dynamics, and the specific context, such as the Israeli-Palestinian conflict).

Furthermore, robust validation protocols, potentially involving consultation with subject matter experts, are essential to ensure that the analysis accurately captures the intended phenomena and its real-world significance. Effectively integrating these diverse skill sets – linguistics, computation, domain expertise, understanding of journalism, and statistical validation – is challenging, and the necessary combination is unfortunately scarce. It underscores the need for genuine interdisciplinary collaboration or consultation to successfully execute such complex, high-stakes research, ensuring that methods are appropriate and findings are reliable.

When the elementary linguistic errors and critically flawed methodology of Jackson’s paper were brought to the attention of the journal’s editors (see Kamm 2025), the only action the editors took was to publish a narrowly worded corrigendum addressing the misidentification of a single example sentence. They declined to correct or even comment on the paper’s general misunderstanding of passives or the systemic flaws identified in its computational methodology. However, after accepting the observation that *More than 67 Palestinians have died* is not a passive, they stated (email from editor Katy J. Parry to Oliver Kamm on 24 March 2025):

We, as co-editors, have discussed this matter and we consider it closed. The article text will be directly corrected for that sentence, in addition to publishing the corrigendum. The computational analysis, using a respected natural

language processing library, is supported with qualitative analysis and illustrative examples.

Parry added that the journal was open to submissions on the topic, and they would be refereed in the normal way:

[W]e would welcome work that develops this field of enquiry Any submissions that meet journal requirements, following our author guidelines, would be dealt with through blind review in the same manner as other submissions we receive.

I will not be responding to further emails about Holly Jackson's article.

We duly prepared a version of the present paper in the journal's format and submitted it to *Media, War & Conflict*, but after seven weeks, on 20 June 2025, a different editor, Richard Stupart, wrote to say that (contradicting Parry's assurance of March 24) they had decided they would not submit it for review.

This disdain for open discussion and normal scholarly procedures of the sort that often leads to retraction of scientific papers, raises serious questions about the adequacy of the journal's post-publication review process and its commitment to upholding basic standards of competence and scientific rigor. Indeed, it brings up considerations of editorial integrity and bias – the very issues Jackson's paper was intended to address in the case of *The New York Times*.

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